

JOSEPH E. GRGIC PRODUCT DESIGNER & RESEARCHER

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14+ Years at Google, Meta, Allstate & Cigna · MS Human Factors

Senior product designer and UX researcher with 14+ years at Google, Meta, Allstate and Cigna, now building and shipping AI products through my own studio. I combine cognitive psychology, human factors engineering and applied AI to design systems where cognitive load and mental models are critical, delivering measurable outcomes across usability, engagement, and adoption.

SKILLS

UX Strategy & Leadership

Cross-Functional Team Leadership

UX Strategy & Roadmapping

Stakeholder Management

Design Thinking & Workshop Facilitation

UX Research Program Management

UX Design & Research Mentorship

Product & Interaction Design

Interaction & Motion Design

Mobile/Responsive Design (iOS, Android)

Design Systems

Information Architecture

Data Visualization

Human-AI Product Design

Applied NLP & Speech Analysis

LLM Integration (Groq, Mistral, GPT)

Human-AI Interaction Design

Conversational & Voice UI

0→1 Product Deployment

Research & Human Factors

Mixed-Methods Research

Usability Testing

Heuristic Evaluation

Cognitive Load & Mental Models

Tools & Technologies

Figma · Sketch · UserTesting · SPSS ·
React · HTML/CSS/JS · Python/FastAPI

WORK EXPERIENCE

vraifactors | Founder & Full-Stack Product Designer

May 2025 - Present

- vraifactors.com — an applied AI studio designing systems where humans stay the decision-makers: observability, directability and human authority as structural requirements.
- vraifrench.com — French pronunciation training that scores speech word-by-word against phonetic rules and explains each miss, built on production-effect and motor-learning research. In pilot with an instructor and their students.
- tauthinking.com — a school-controlled AI chat for coursework that makes student thinking visible: a four-dimension agency framework and turn-level pattern detection show teachers how the work was produced. In pilot with two US schools.

Allstate | Sr. Product Designer (Contract)

May 2023 - Dec 2024

- Led Apple/Google Pay integration with platform liaisons, payments engineering and legal: 92% transaction success, 85% confidence, 50% fewer steps, MVP in <3 months.
- Redesigned the messaging and alert system, increasing engagement by 7% via intuitive hierarchy and mapping, improving KPIs (payments, enrollments) and account management.
- Implemented an enterprise-hosted LLM for qualitative synthesis under PII constraints, validating outputs against manual analysis to control for hallucination and preserve findings integrity.

Meta | Sr. UX Researcher (Contract)

Jan 2023 - May 2023

- Identified findability as the top usability issue for 52% of sellers via unmoderated testing (n=33), prioritizing IA/UI redesigns to reduce page views and improve task completion rates to increase seller transactions and spend.
- Improved SFI email capture adoption by identifying seller hesitations via moderated user testing. Translated insights into UX solutions, resulting in +0.63% GMV and a 16% reduction in churn.
- Led Shops/Shopify seller research program, delivering 3 studies/month to uncover seller pain points. Insights directly informed feature optimizations and adoption strategies.

Terakeet | UX Manager | Assoc. Director

May 2020 - Dec 2022

- Built the UX department from the ground up — hired and managed a team of 12 — embedding design-thinking across client and product teams.
- Created a new CRO service line from scratch, extending the agency's offering and bringing UX methodology into fintech client engagements.
- Advocated and built out an internal design system using the atomic model to improve consistency, facilitate collaboration between teams and products, and improve design and engineering efficiency.

Cigna | Sr. UX Designer & Team Lead

Jan 2019 - Mar 2020

- Architected the UX strategy for Cigna's enterprise data 360 initiative, designing a node-edge visualization tool with drill-down and filtering that let non-technical users self-generate reports — replacing a multi-day team process with one person in a single day.
- Managed a team of seven UX designers offering mentorship and growth opportunities while managing product stakeholders to ensure alignment of goals and deliverables.

EDUCATION

MS Human Factors

Missouri Western State University 2011

BS Psychology

Iowa State University 2009

Google | Sr. UX Designer (Contract)

Jan 2018 - Jan 2019

- Redesigned the Editor Ads tool to full M2 compliance — reducing mouse travel and cognitive load with no regression on power-user task speed, and establishing a reusable component baseline that removed per-feature M2 re-evaluation.
- Facilitated a rapid UX workshop to optimize Google Ads' notification framework, driving prioritization of p0 alerts and adaptive in-line CTAs based on user task; delivered actionable design strategies for visual prominence, content organization, and glanceable hierarchy to balance user control with guided automation.
- Led end-to-end design and research for automated bidding, building advertiser understanding of how the system decides on their behalf — driving adoption.

Method (McDonald's) | Sr. UX Designer

Mar 2017 – Nov 2017

- Pioneered a unified Loyalty & Payment system (Voice/QR Badges) using geofence-triggered access and gesture controls (e.g., shake-to-launch), unifying transactions and boosting order efficiency through real world prototyping and testing.
- Launched Post-Fulfillment CX tools – dynamic eReceipts, curbside parking spot support, and feedback loops – cutting drive-thru delays and improving satisfaction through real-time issue resolution.
- Built out the service design for an omni-channel experience, integrating Voice UI – conversational turn-taking, error repair, and confirmation patterns that carry directly into today's AI interfaces – to improve ordering while holding to core KPIs.

Havas Life | Principal/Director of UX

Mar 2012 – Mar 2017

- Led UX and interaction design across multiple digital platforms, establishing a user-centered design culture internally and with clients, resulting in reduced design and implementation timelines within budget constraints.
- Created responsive web frameworks and created iOS-based CLM platforms design frameworks across multi-brand portfolios, using analytics-driven iteration to boost customer engagement and sales.
- Served as UX lead, designer, developer, and project manager, growing digital business to over \$40M annually while maintaining an agile design process focused on delivering KPI-driven outcomes.

Merck | UX Research Consultant

Feb 2012 – Mar 2012

- Set up a UX research lab for the internal UX team, providing recommendations on research software, methodologies, and deliverables.
- Piloted a global remote usability study across US, EU, and Asia on internal Merck tools using mouseflow tracking to map how teams used internal tools and surface areas for improvement.

DDB | Sr. UX Designer

Nov 2011 – Feb 2012

- Led four teams to map out State Farm's current service design model and capabilities, identify pain points, and create solutions to meet their needs across all business products.
- Integrated business products to create seamless user experience and reduce agent demand and time (e.g. accident - claim - reimbursement - loan) with a focus on a fully digital, iOS-first experience.
- Developed the user flow for mobile billing and payments to enable payments across multiple products, using multiple payment methods, with a focus on clarity, building trust, and security.